

Discussing Language within Health Fields: Illness as a “Fight”

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Introduction

George Lakoff and Mark Johnson are both important philosophers who have studied the development of metaphor. They argue that metaphor is not just decorative language used to engage people, but something that structures what is “pervasive in everyday life, not just in language but in thought and action.” (Lakoff and Johnson) Ultimately, they argue that a metaphor’s structure helps us understand reality. For example, one prominent metaphor present within health field language today is the description of what patients go through when they have a disease or illness as a “fight.” This specific metaphor appears on CDC websites, which use phrases such as “the fight against ALS,” as well as in the language of the American Institute for Cancer Research, which states, “Foods that Fight Cancer.” Lakoff and Johnson would agree that metaphor criticism works well with interpreting this metaphor because through this method it allows us to reveal how framing disease as a “fight” shapes how audiences understand illness and treatment.

The use of “fighting” or “fight” in this structure and environment does not mean that people are literally battling, but instead reveals something else at a more symbolic level. The intended audience for this metaphor is people who may not understand the specifics of a disease or how it is treated. More than likely the audience for this metaphor is targeted to the general public. Therefore, the term “fight” responds to the issue that people may not fully grasp the complexities involved in treating and managing illness. The language that shape how these websites communicate include the need to simplify complex medical information for a general audience, as well as this cultural concept that people see other people dealing with disease or

illness as a strength. While the metaphor of illness as a “fight” helps simplify complex medical ideas for the general audience, it ultimately oversimplifies disease or illness by framing illness as a battle of strength and survival rather than the specific biological process.

Isolate and Analyze the Metaphor

An article written by the Stony Brook Cancer Center mentions multiple instances in which it uses the metaphor of “fighting” or “fight.” This ultimately helps the general public understand what exactly the body does in preventing cancer, as well as how a person can help their immune system fight it. For instance, the article states, “Immunotherapy is a form of medical treatment that activates your immune system to help fight cancer.” Using the metaphor “fight” in this specific context helps portray immunotherapy as a weapon. Making this connection through metaphor supports the argument that immunotherapy helps the body recover from cancer in a tool- or weapon-like way. One association that this specific metaphor “fight” creates is that treatment becomes a symbolic weapon, and the patient must use this figurative weapon to eliminate the disease. Some qualities that come with the use of this metaphor imply that strength is needed when receiving treatment for cancer, because when people think of a battle, they imagine individuals needing strength to wield a weapon. Because of this assumption, one might think that people dealing with cancer are warriors with the strength to use treatment effectively as one would do within a fight. Although this specific metaphor helps people understand what it might be like to heal and undergo treatment for cancer. But it also leaves out important information, such as the specifics of how immunotherapy actually activates the immune system. By leaving out this information, the audience is left with a simplified understanding that the treatment helps get rid of cancer without fully understanding how it works.

The Carondelet Health Network uses metaphoric language on its website when discussing “Nine Ways to Strengthen Your Immune System.” There are mentions of “fighting” and “strength” as metaphors to help explain how our bodies heal from illness. A specific quote from the website is, “The stronger the immune system, the better the opportunity to fight off illness.” The argument this metaphor makes is that the body can actively defend itself against illness. This leads to associations such as the immune system acting like armor for the body, preventing attack. It also encourages the idea that illness is some kind of physical enemy that must be defeated. Also some of the imagery this metaphor creates is that the immune system is a reinforced shield that must be constantly maintained so it is prepared for any kind of battle or conflict with the “enemy,” which is illness. Another issue within this framing is that, because there is no mention of the metaphor failing, it may lead a general audience to believe they will not get sick if they continually strengthen their immune system. However, this is not realistic, as it is still very possible for someone to develop a disease.

One last quote that stuck out to me came from the Mayo Clinic, and within this website it discusses things that can help with inflammation, but again uses the word “fight” to describe how dieting might help it, without directly saying how it helps it. The quote from this website that I want to analyze in a metaphorical criticism context is “certain foods can either fuel or fight inflammation”. The argument this metaphor is trying to make is that foods can either help with giving energy to your body or help lessen inflammation. The way this metaphor frames this though leads to associations that the inflammation on your body is this enemy and threat. While food can be something of a warrior to fight this threat. Some of the things I picture are a battlefield that the food is in warrior clothes fighting this big red swollen evil villain of inflammation. Also a value that I feel like this might be communicating through this metaphor is

this idea of hope. Fighting, I feel always has an end and usually when someone is the one fighting something they win. I feel like people who have inflammation, will see it as hope that specific foods will fight and then win against the inflammation itself. That after reading this text, the audience will have this type of false hope. Giving false hope can add to this level of miscommunication, because in reality we don't know if dieting correctly will fully help you get over all of your inflammation. The message that this metaphor is leaving out is how exactly it "fight" inflammation, and what specifically about the food allows it to help reduce the inflammation. Maybe talking in more detail about it will help with misunderstandings.

Conclusion

The use of the metaphor "fighting" or "fight" in relation to disease or illness is meant to quickly inform the general audience that something is working against the disease in some way, whether that be treatment or the person's own body. It implies that someone or something is actively challenging the illness. This is highly effective because it indirectly communicates what is happening in a way that the general public can easily understand and digest. Potential effects on how audiences respond to hearing "fight" in a medical context may include imagining an actual battle or conflict. Some may associate it with hope and perseverance. It structures a reality for the audience that suggests there is armor, protection, or some means of battling the disease to prevent it from worsening. The metaphor also creates the implication that one side must be winning or losing in this battle and that there will eventually be an end, though this is not always the case. While the use of illness as a fighting metaphor is effective in simplifying medical information, reducing disease to a battle can produce more problematic effects than positive ones, such as failing to provide necessary details. Necessary details such as how does this

someone or something “fight”? What specifically does this “fight” look like? By focusing on this medical fight, the metaphor leaves out the complexity and biology of what is actually happening.

Work Cited

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